

The Familiar Dark — Build Milestones

Production milestones for the 13-day jam. Companion to the plot document (the_familiar_dark_plot.md) and the backstory outline (the-familiar-dark-story-outline.md). Each build is a playable demo of the game-so-far.

Build 1 — Town & Act 0 (Days 1-2)

Town map with all load-bearing locations:

- Aldric's office
- Nessa's cell
- **The Mouthstone Exile Gate** at the town's edge — huge black monolith, vertical split, half-sunk in old ritual ground. Visible as constant foreshadowing.
- The statue cordon
- Shop
- Save point

Opening Intercessor ceremony cutscene. Aldric's procedural-mercy briefing. First Nessa conversation — she admits she wanted contact, admits she broke rules, refuses *witch*.

Nessa's Carried Stone introduced as a flavor item she keeps with her — mundane on the surface, half devotional token, half wound.

End state: Town walkable. Mouthstone visible. Carried Stone seeded.

Build 2 — Pagan Network & The Witness-Rite (Days 3-5)

Compact under-place — cellars, old stone channels, hidden shrines, crawlspaces, river drains, ritual rooms. Not a megadungeon.

- 2-3 enemy types: rite remnants, partial Glass conversions, residual pressure
- Player has 3-4 skills with real targeting patterns

- Find Mara's specific basement
- Find Tollen and Iria's pagan-side connections
- Recover the lock of Mara's hair fused to Glass remains
- Learn forbidden witness-work from a hidden source

End-beat cutscene: witness-rite performed. Mara briefly wakes. *"I opened."* Aldric refuses — contaminated, inadmissible. Her testimony points toward the pagan lands as the only place physical evidence remains.

End state: Act 1 complete. Player has truth but not admissible proof.

Build 3 — Drowned River Shrine (Days 6-8)

Old pagan river site. Glass reeds, black-red water, Glass fish, stained stones, current-borne memory.

- 2-3 new enemy types
- Aldric tells the damning childhood story
- **Playable Nessa flashback** — young Nessa in the river, frightened imperfect rescue attempt, someone hurt, town's need to blame. Player feels the pattern: consequence becomes guilt, disobedience makes intent invisible.
- **The Carried Stone is contextualized** — Aldric gave it to her after the childhood incident, meant as discipline. Nessa kept it as evidence she survived being blamed. The stone is older than Aldric knows.
- Return to town: Nessa's dialogue has shifted; she trusts the player more.

End state: Act 2 complete. The Carried Stone is positioned as load-bearing.

Build 4 — Verdict, Exile Gate, Pagan Lands (Days 9-12)

Verdict cutscene. Church condemns Nessa.

Exile Gate cutscene. Mouthstone activates with the Sending Seal. Nessa passes through. Player follows.

Pagan Lands as Act 3 proper — fracture-realm, not hostile country:

- Lost condemned people who did not simply die
- Failed rites continuing without witnesses
- Old pagan structures that remember names better than doctrine does
- Glass that does not follow Church explanations
- 2-3 new enemy types
- Find the **Return Stone** — in a ruined river altar, root-bound shrine, or at the monolith's other face
- Carried Stone + Return Stone unite — **Recall Seal awakens**
- **Enlightenment moment** — false categories break. Nessa and player perceive the true shape of the catastrophe.
- Find **physical proof** — an event wound, Glass-negative imprint that records the order of contact at the original rite.
- Encounter Nessa in the lands — she belongs here more than she expected, but not because she's guilty.

End state: Act 3 complete. Recall Seal mastered. Physical proof in hand. Choice presented.

Build 5 — Endings & Polish (Day 13)

Return With Nessa. Break/complete the Recall Seal. Bring Nessa back through the Mouthstone. Carry physical proof into town. Force rupture. Aldric forced to choose between the law and the person he heard truly named. Town must face that exile was not mercy.

Stay Beyond. Master the Recall Seal enough to know return is possible. Refuse to return Nessa to the court that broke her. Remain with her beyond.

Audio pass from the fusion library. Bug fixes. Final playthrough. Submit.

Where intricacy lives — woven through every build

- **Nessa's cell dialogue evolves** through ~5 states as evidence accumulates: angry-and-difficult → guarded → trusting → desperate (post-witness-rite refusal) → resigned (pre-exile). You never get the same conversation twice.
- **The Carried Stone as Chekhov's gun.** Mentioned in Build 1, contextualized in Build 3,

payoff in Build 4. Attentive players notice it early; the payoff lands either way.

- **Lore documents that matter** — Church doctrine establishing orthodoxy, Nessa's marginalia in stolen texts, pagan rite fragments, condemned-people testimonies in the Pagan Lands the Church refuses to collect, the near-witness rite text as a key item.
 - **Class affects investigation.** Scholar reads documents deeper, Warrior intimidates, Mystic perceives cyberghost traces and event wounds others miss. Same case, different paths.
 - **Enemies of the world** — rite remnants, drowned echoes, Glass-touched things, condemned-dead, failed-rite manifestations. Every encounter thematic.
 - **Aldric's reactions to evidence** programmed across the whole game — every clue rationalized toward guilt, his refusal at the witness-rite earned, his absence in Act 3 felt.
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Scope cuts in the back pocket

If days disappear:

- Pagan Lands trimmed to one focused area instead of multiple sub-zones
- Classes cut to 2 from 3
- Enemy variety reduced via palette swaps
- One of the two endings shortened (probably Stay Beyond — Return forces a full town return scene)